THE VIETNAM WAR

THE GULF OF TONKIN INCIDENT



Date August 2-4, 1964
Forces Americans: 2 destroyers; North Vietnamese: 5–8 torpedo boats
Losses Americans: none; North Vietnamese: c.3 boats destroyed

Location Gulf of Tonkin, North Vietnam

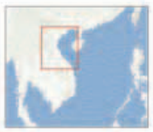
The Gulf of Tonkin incident provided a pretext for escalating US involvement in the Vietnam War. On August 2, 1964, the destroyer USS *Maddox* was engaged in intelligence-gathering off the Gulf of Tonkin when she was approached by three North Vietnamese torpedo boats. Warning shots failed to deter the attackers, and US gunfire subsequently destroyed one boat and damaged another. Two days later *Maddox* was on patrol with another destroyer, *Turner Joy*. Radio operators on board suddenly reported five enemy torpedo boats approaching, resulting in a blaze of US gunfire and reports that two enemy craft had been sunk. Later analysis contended that the reports were false and no enemy craft were present. Nonetheless, the incidents led to retaliatory air attacks on North Vietnam and persuaded US Congress to effectively commit to war.



Jet warfare
Deck crew on board the carrier *Bon Homme Richard* prepare F-8 Crusader fighter jets for action against North Vietnamese aircraft in 1965.

THE VIETNAM WAR

OPERATION ROLLING THUNDER



Date March 2, 1965–November 1,1968
Forces Americans: 600 ships; North Vietnamese: extensive Soviet-supplied air defenses
Losses Americans: 922 aircraft; North Vietnamese: unknown

Location Gulf of Tonkin and North Vietnam

Rolling Thunder was the name of the aerial bombing campaign over North Vietnam, initiated in March 1965 with the intention of pounding the North Vietnamese government into submission. A sustained bombing campaign, carried out over several years, inflicted huge damage—air force, navy, and Marine Corps aircraft dropped 864,000 tons of bombs—but ultimately failed to break North Vietnamese resistance or convince the government not to aid Communist insurgency in the South.

The US Navy and Marine Corps component of Rolling Thunder was primarily delivered by the carrier aircraft of "Yankee Station" based 75 miles (140 km) off the Gulf of Tonkin. Yankee Station consisted of multiple US aircraft carriers during the Rolling Thunder operations, including *Coral Sea*, *Hancock*, *Constellation*, and *Midway*. By operating in a multi-carrier unit, Yankee Station was able to keep up the round-the-clock commitments of the air war. Its aviators ran terrible risks from Soviet-supplied SA-2 Guideline missiles and vast barrages of conventional anti-aircraft fire. There were also some horrific offshore accidents, the most famous of which resulted from the accidental firing of a Zuni rocket aboard USS *Forrestal* on July 29, 1967. The missile ignited fuel and ordnance, and subsequent fires and detonations killed 134 and destroyed or damaged 64 aircraft. In total, 454 naval aviators and many more air force pilots died during Operation Rolling Thunder.

THE VIETNAM WAR

OPERATION MARKET TIME



Date March 11,1965–December 1972
Forces Americans: unknown; North Vietnamese: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Coastal waters of South Vietnam

On February 16, 1965, a US helicopter flying along the coast of central South Vietnam spotted a North Vietnamese trawler unloading arms and ammunition at Vung Ro Bay—the first tangible evidence that North Vietnam was using open sea routes to supply Communist insurgents in South Vietnam. The US Navy responded to the incident by launching Market Time, a major coastal patrol operation designed to cut the open–water supply lines between North and South Vietnam.

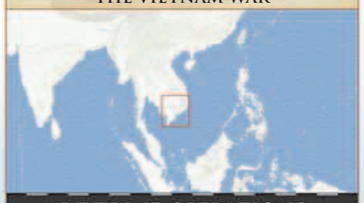
Operation Market Time ran for seven years along a 1,200 mile (2,000 km) stretch of the South Vietnamese coast. It was delivered by Task Force 115, the Coastal Patrol Force. By 1966 hundreds of US Navy, Coast Guard, and South Vietnamese Navy craft were involved. The screening operation was organized around nine patrol sectors stretching 40 miles (65 km) out to sea. Close to the shore, US Navy Patrol Gunboats, armed junks, and Coast Guard Cutters performed stop-and-search operations. Further from the coast, larger navy minesweepers and destroyers intercepted deep-water traffic. US Navy surveillance aircraft patrolled the waters beyond.

The effect of Market Time on the Communist supply lines was profound. Out of 50 North Vietnamese trawlers that attempted the run south between 1965 and 1972, US forces captured or destroyed 49. Communist forces almost entirely abandoned the coastal route in favor of the inland Ho Chi Minh Trail.

The SEALORDS program ran until 1970, when the Brown Water efforts began to wind down, having killed thousands of Viet Cong personnel and stemmed the Communist flow of supplies to and from Cambodia. The Riverine War was a dirty, violent campaign, but it had played a vital role in the efforts to destroy the Viet Cong.

Monitor on patrol
An American Swift patrol boat converted into an armored monitor gunboat churns slowly past defoliated vegetation during counter-insurgency operations on the Saigon River.

THE VIETNAM WAR



RIVERINE OPERATIONS

Date	1965–1970
Location	Principally the Mekong River Delta
Result	US superiority

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES	VIET CONG

COMMANDERS

William Westmoreland	Local commanders

FORCES

Ships: 258 patrol and minesweeping boats, 184 monitors and transports, 25 helicopter gunships, 15 aircraft in 1969	**Ships:** unknown

LOSSES

Men: 5,182 **Ships:** unknown	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** unknown